



Schedule

Quarterfinal 1: August 28-31, 2025: North Zone vs East Zone

Quarterfinal 2: August 28-31, 2025: Central Zone vs NorthEast Zone

Semifinal 1: September 4-7, 2025: South Zone vs Winner QF1

Semifinal 2: September 4-7, 2025: West Zone vs Winner QF2

Final: September 11-15, 2025: Winner SF 1 vs Winner SF 2

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The Duleep Trophy returns to its traditional zonal structure after last year's experiment with a four-team all-star format, bringing with it renewed regional pride and high stakes for players eager to impress national selectors. Long seen as a bridge between domestic cricket

and India A selection, the tournament has always been a litmus test for both emerging talent and seasoned performers.

When the competition gets underway on August 28 at the BCCI's new Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru, players from the six zones — North, South, East, West, Central,

Waiting game: After a bright Test start with fifties on debut against England and a 150 versus New Zealand in Bengaluru, Sarfaraz Khan was left out of the England tour for Karun Nair. He now lines up for West Zone in the Duleep Trophy. B.JOTHI RAMALINGAM

and North-East — will have plenty to play for. With the domestic season looming and two India A Tests against Australia A on the horizon, this edition promises to be both competitive and consequential.

Back to basics

The BCCI has mandated that India's Test players feature in domestic tournaments whenever available, and this year's squads are packed with familiar names.

North Zone named India's Test captain Shubman Gill as skipper, though doubts remain over his participation as he has been unwell. Even if Gill pulls out, the squad boasts quality with left-arm quick Arshdeep Singh and promising pacers Harshit Rana and Anshul Kamboj.

West Zone looks equally formidable, with Shreyas Iyer, Sarfaraz Khan, Ruturaj Gaikwad, and Yashasvi Jaiswal forming a heavyweight batting order under the leadership of Shardul Thakur.

East Zone has plenty of firepower too. Mohammed Shami, Mukesh Kumar, and Riyan Parag provide depth across departments, while Abhimanyu Easwaran will lead until Ishan Kishan joins later in the campaign.

Central Zone could emerge as the dark horse. Dhruv Jurel captains with Rajat Patidar as deputy, while Kuldeep Yadav, Khaleel Ahmed, and Deepak Chahar lead a varied attack.

For the North-East Zone, led by Nagaland's Rongsen Jonathan, the tournament represents a rare but vital opportunity to test itself against higher-quality opposition.

Not all squads, however, have complied with the BCCI's directive. The board expressed disappointment with South Zone for leaving out K.L. Rahul, Mohammed Siraj, Washington Sundar, Sai Sudharsan, and Prasidh Krishna from its initial squad. Tilak